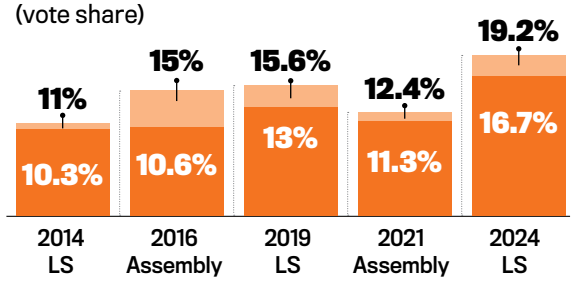


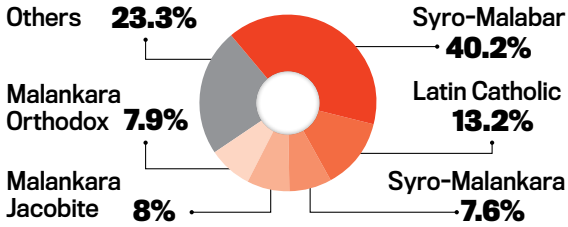
SLOWLY BUT SURELY

BJP/NDA poll performance in Kerala
(vote share)



18.4% **Christian population in Kerala**

The Different Denominations



NGOs are now directed to open accounts only in the New Delhi branch of the State Bank of India if they want to receive foreign contributions. In such a vindictive climate, the Church will have to yield…it's a question of survival," he says.

Paul Zacharia, perhaps Malayalam's most celebrated short story writer and a Syrian Christian by birth, is not so sure about who to blame. "Historically, the Christians have always opted for political propositions that were to their advantage. They sabotaged the first Communist government in Kerala, they never opposed the Emergency, and now they are falling for the BJP. It's as if they are playing lucky dip," says the 79-year-old author.

A CHRISTIAN OVERTURE

The saffron party is focusing on five Lok Sabha constituencies where the Christians can play a decisive role in deciding winners—Thiruvananthapuram (19.1 per cent of voters), Attingal (19 per cent), Pathanamthitta (39.7 per cent), Alappuzha (19.8 per cent) and Thrissur. Scheduled Caste constituency Mavelikkara (21.8 per cent), Chalakudy (32.1 per cent), Palakkad (4.1 per cent) and Kasargod (7.8 per cent) are also listed to improve the vote share in the state. Though Palakkad and Kasargod have fewer Christians, the BJP's internal surveys suggest that, as in Kottayam, Islamophobia is strong among Christians in these seats.

Now that is a thread the saffron party knows how to tease out well. 'Love jihad' was one of the themes that first brought the BJP and the Church together in the past decade and a half. The party has now also thrown its weight behind the 600-odd families (mostly Christian) in coastal Munambam, Kochi, in a face-off with the state Waqf board which says their homes were on the board's land.

Not many are sure, though, that the BJP's religious polarisation plan will work in Kerala. "The BJP game plan will fail as the people are more intelligent than the church leaders. That was amply evident in Christian-dominated Pathanamthitta [the party had fielded Anil Antony here, son of veteran Congress leader A.K. Antony, but still lost here] in the last parliamentary poll," says political analyst Sunnykutti Abraham. What concerns him is a Congress implosion and the "anti-Communists" shifting to the BJP as the next available political option. The fears are not unwarranted; in the past few days, some of the top state Congress leaders have been caught in a war of words over, of all things, who will be the next party CM.

The BJP agenda is also along those lines, destabilising the Congress and throttling the CPI(M). The 10 Lok Sabha constituencies they are focusing on account for 70 seats in the 140-member assembly. If the Christians fall in line, the BJP could win 45 of these seats. State BJP president K. Surendran, as always, is supremely confident. "We are sure that we will form the government in 2026. The public mood is in our favour. Kerala has benefitted from PM Modi's development programmes," he says.

From nil seats to 45 and even forming government, the party's ambitions are clear. The BJP's plans hold no surprises—a mix of religious polarisation, caste politics and a sprinkling of Magic Modi dust. The timing, too, is not inopportune, Congress factions are pulling against each other and the ruling CPI(M) is sinking under the weight of anti-incumbency and controversies that a decade in power has wrought. The question is whether the BJP can acquire the critical mass necessary to bring down the last Red citadel in the country. ■